remembered as a social reformer and ‘pioneering champion of the downtrodden’.[6]

Caldwell made his home in the district of Tirunelveli (known to the British as Tinnevelly) on the banks of the Thamirabarani (known to the British as the Tamraparni) River, the most southerly of the country’s great rice-bowls. Caldwell saw the Thamirabarani as the region’s life force, and in his *Political and general history of the district of Tinnevelly* he wrote that: ‘If the history of the dawn of a higher civilisation in Tinnevelly could be brought to light, I have no doubt that the Tamraparni, the great river of Tinnevelly, would be found to occupy the most prominent place in the picture. It must have been the facilities afforded by this stream for the cultivation of rice which attracted to its banks family after family of settlers from the north.’[7]

What makes the Thamirabarani exceptional is that it is fed by both summer and winter monsoons, and so comes into full flood twice a year. This is because it has its source in the last outcrops of the Western Ghats, at the foot of a ‘noble conical mountain’ known variously as Pothigai, Pothiyam, or Pothiya-ma-malai, all meaning ‘a place of concealment’, but also as Agastya Malai, or ‘the hill of Agastya’, arising, as Caldwell explained, ‘from the tradition that the great *rishi* Agastya, when he retired from the world after civilising the south, took up his abode in its inaccessible recesses. It is long supposed by all Natives to be inaccessible, on account of the force of the charms with which Agastya had fenced in his retreat.’

Rishi Agastya and his sacred mountain sanctuary come under deeper scrutiny in the next chapter, but the point that Caldwell wanted to make was that this twice-yearly run-off from Pothigai Malai was what made rice cultivation possible. The annual rainfall on its summit was found to amount to 300 inches by a certain Dr Broun, astronomer to the Maharaja of Travancore, who had ignored local prohibitions